

Islamic art

During the 17th and 18th centuries, Islamic art blossomed across three Islamic Empires: the Ottoman Empire from Turkey to Tunisia, the Safavids in Iran, and the Mughals in India. The Ottomans produced magnificent architecture such as the Blue Mosque in Istanbul, decorated tiles and pottery, and exacting manuscript and book illustrations. Safavid art, meanwhile, featured Chinese and Mongol influences.

Mughal art at first displayed features of Safavid art, but later followed its own path. It developed under the emperor Humāyūn (1530–40 and 1555–56), through two Persian artists, Mīr Sayyid ‘Alī and Khwāja ‘Abd al-Samad. Humāyūn’s son Akbar (1556–1605) employed more court painters and commissioned dynamic illustrated histories with elements of realism and naturalism. Under Jahangir (1605–27), it developed further. Inspired by European painting, brushwork became finer and colours lighter. In the reign of Shah Jahan (1628–58), it was architecture that reached new heights, culminating with the Taj Mahal in 1648.



Shen Nanpi, *Bahadur Shah II*, 1844